was a brigade of four diesel electric-powered submarines, each carrying these weapons, that may have posed the greatest threat of inadvertent nuclear war in the missile crisis. According to Martin Sherwin, 'It is no exaggeration to suggest there were two Soviet missile crises: The first involved Soviet ground, air, and rocket forces sent to Cuba; the second and far more dangerous one – involved the Soviet navy's submarines.'[85]

The confrontation between US ASW forces and four Soviet Project 641 submarines occurred as the diplomatic crisis reached its climax. Several of the Project 641s were subjected to attacks designed to get them to surface. These events may have created the moment when we came closest to the deliberate use of nuclear weapons in the Cold War. They are discussed in chapter seven. The focus here is whether procedures for dealing with Soviet submarines involved 'probing questions to military recommendations'. It is clear they were not. It is equally clear that the recommendations (or rather actions) of Defense Secretary McNamara were not subjected to probing questions on matters that in hindsight might have proved catastrophic.

The challenge posed by Soviet submarines was fully recognised by US military and political leaders (though the President and some of his advisers harboured the odd delusion that they would be able to bring nuclear warheads into Cuba). The threat against US surface ships loomed large in ExComm as they waited for the blockade to come into effect at 10.00am on Wednesday, 24 October, and to see whether Soviets ships would seek to run the blockade. Robert Kennedy's account of the meeting of ExComm conveys the tension and his brother's anxiety. The Presidential Recordings provide a minute-by minute record of how members of ExComm reacted.

Around 10.25am (EDT) news began filtering through to ExComm that some Soviet ships had stopped or were turning around. This came as McNamara was explaining how the blockade was being enforced. Two Soviet ships – the *Kimovsk* and the *Yuri Gagarin* – were approaching the 500-mile barrier and were (correctly) suspected of carrying material covered by the quarantine restrictions. The *Kimovsk*, and possibly the *Gagarin*, would be intercepted that day by US destroyers (so the Defense Secretary believed).